tasted the benefits of technology peace and prosperity that the British had brought to India

School textbooks actively urged students to acculturate to become Anglicized and Westernized and to leave behind the decadent accretions of their indigenous pasts After acculturation would come prominent positions within British India schoolbooks promised, it was the British governments intention as one text put it "to offer a large share in the administration to natives of India who were qualified by character and education" (Thompson 1908 393) The educational system however, taught more than a simple message of acculturation It also taught schoolboys about Indias "degenerate" past and their own "weak" and/or "effeminate" natures Caste idolatry the treatment of women Indias debilitating climate and vegetarianism were according to schoolbooks responsible for Indias backward and superstitious culture and its puny and small citizenry The nationalist leader Mohandas K Gandhi (1869–1948) recalled from his Gujarati youth a verse that ran

> *Behold the mighty Englishman*
> *He rules the Indian small,*
> *Because being a meat-eater*
> *He is five cubits tall. (1957, 21)*

British racism was institutionalized within an educational system that simultaneously taught Indian inferiority and British superiority These superior Western qualities and inferior Indian counterparts became base points of a core identity increasingly internalized over the 19th and 20th centuries in succeeding generations of English-educated families After graduation employment in British institutions or under British superiors introduced the educated elite to racial prejudices but in more personal circumstances One English-educated Punjabi gentleman for instance worked as an engineer for the government in turn-of-the-century India and admired many qualities of his British employers but at work he had the sense of being always "on test" The British his son remembers the father saying "could afford to relax because if things went wrong they managed to explain it to each other But when an Indian made a mistake the reaction if an understanding one was that the job perhaps was too difficult for him" (Tandon 1968 216–217)

Religious and Social Reform Associations

"The Life of the Educated Native What Should It Be" This was the title of a student essay in the 1870s and a question many Western

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educated Indians asked themselves in the second half of the 19th century. Rationalism and the Enlightenment were the keys to a modern future, just as caste, idolatry, and superstition were its anathema. But beyond schoolbook formulas lay the thornier realm of actual practice. The wearing of a sacred thread, prohibitions against eating beef, restrictions on commensality (sharing food across caste lines), prohibitions against the use of utensils for eating and against overseas travel, the ban on widow remarriage, and the customs of child marriage and of purdah—all were linked to social practices embedded in Hindu daily and domestic life. The changed conditions of life in British-ruled India politicized these practices (and many more), precipitating debates and conflicts within Westernized communities. The religious and social reform associations that formed over the latter half of the 19th century were the contexts in which the Western-educated debated the degree to which they would adapt themselves, their religions, and the Indian past to the ideas and practices of British colonial modernity.

The Brahmo Samaj and the Prarthana Samaj

Originally founded by Rammohun Roy in 1828, the Brahmo Samaj expanded throughout the second half of the 19th century, gaining new followers and splitting several times over issues of practice. By the end of the century, Brahmos functioned almost as a separate caste within Bengali Hindu society. They had their own religious beliefs and practices, their own "churches," and their own social rituals. Their children's marriages were arranged within the Brahmo community.

In the 1840s and 1850s Debendranath Tagore (1817–1905) renewed the Brahmo Samaj as a religious association committed to the monotheistic worship of a formless deity. Then, in 1866, Keshab Chandra Sen (1838–84) left Tagore's society to found the Brahmo Samaj of India, a society in which members could aggressively practice their religious beliefs. Sen's Brahmos refused to wear the Hindu sacred thread or to perform Hindu rituals or death ceremonies, practices that provoked violence, ostracism, and disinheritance from converts' families. Sen established ashrams, hostels for Brahmo converts who needed shelter, and his Brahmos traveled throughout Bengal and India as missionaries, spreading the Brahmo faith. In 1878, however, when Sen ignored Brahmo reforms in order to marry his daughter to a Hindu prince, younger members left him to form the Sadharan Brahmo Samaj (the People's Brahmo Samaj), a sect with even more reformist practices, particularly in regard to women. Sadharan girls wore petticoats under

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The Sadharan Brahmo Samaj (the People's Brahmo Samaj) was formed by a split away from Keshab Sen's Brahmo group in 1878 over differences in the practice of the Brahmos' monotheistic faith. The building for the new sect was begun the next year on Cornwallis Street (now Bidhan Sarani) in Calcutta. Debendranath Tagore, although himself still a member of the original Brahmo group (the Adi Brahmo Samaj), gave 7,000 rupees toward the building project. The new mandir (temple) opened in 1881. (courtesy of Judith E. Walsh)

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their saris and ate at European-style tables using Western utensils; they studied math and science and were encouraged to go to college.

Sen's missionary lectures in Bombay inspired the founding there in the late 1860s of a West Indian religious reform group, the Prarthana Samaj (Prayer Society). One of its early leaders, Mahadev Govind Ranade (1842–1901), was a Chitpavan Brahman from the Konkan region who became a lawyer and later judge in the Pune region. The Prarthana Samaj shared Brahmo ideas on monotheism and on the desirability of reforming caste customs, particularly in regard to women, but, as elsewhere, orthodox pressure could make it difficult to translate these beliefs into practice. Ranade, for instance, spent much of his life working for social reform, arranging Bombay's first widow remarriage in 1862, founding the Society for the Encouragement of Widow Remarriage shortly thereafter, and later (1884) founding the Deccan Education Society to promote girls' education (Wolpert 1962, 111). But when his first wife died in 1873, he did not marry a Hindu widow, as he had long advocated and as he wished, instead he accepted the 11-year-old bride chosen for him by his father.

Muslim Education and Reform

Writing about conditions in India after the 1857 rebellion, the well-known Urdu poet Maulana Altaf Hussain Hali (1837–1914) said:

> *We [Muslims] are not trusted by the government,*
> *Nor are we among the prominent courtiers of the ruler.*
> *Neither are we among the educated elite.*
> *We have no share in trade or the industry.*
> *Nor do you found [sic] us in the civil services.*
> *Or among the businesses. . . . (Khalidi 1995, 52)*

Muslim elites had been slow to enlist under the British rulers who had replaced them, and Muslim families had been reluctant to enroll their sons in English language schools. But Muslim religious leaders were not unaware of the changed society around them. Northern Indian Muslim elites saw their control over positions in regional government services steadily decreasing in the second half of the 19th century, from 65 percent in 1857 to 33 percent by the early 20th century, as Muslims lost ground to English-educated applicants from Hindu trading, money-lending, and professional communities.

The six years between 1868 and 1875 saw the founding of competing Muslim educational institutions in the towns of Deoband and Aligarh in northern India (modern Uttar Pradesh). These two institu-

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tions appealed to different levels of elite Muslim society and offered different responses to British rule in India. The Deoband Dar-al-Ulum was a madrassa (religious seminary) founded in 1868 for the education of Muslim *ulama* (theologian scholars). It took an orthodox approach to Islamic studies, attracted poorer but elite Muslim students, and produced teachers for local religious schools throughout its region. Deoband offered a traditional Islamic curriculum. But it taught in Western-style classrooms modeled on the British school system and used the North Indian language Urdu. In the 20th century Deoband's relatively anti-British politics would cause its teachers, students, and graduates to align themselves with the Indian nationalist movement.

The other school, the Muhammadan Anglo-Oriental College, was the first Muslim English language college in India. It was founded at Aligarh in 1875 by the Muslim reformer (and later Muslim separatist) Sir Sayyid Ahmad Khan (1817–98). Sayyid Ahmad's family was highly placed within the Mughal nobility at Delhi, but he himself had worked many years under the British. He founded the Scientific Society in 1864 and a modern Urdu language journal in 1870, hoping through these media to demonstrate to upper-class Muslims that Western science was compatible with and complementary to the teachings of Islam. Impressed by Western colleges on a trip to England in 1875, Sayyid Ahmad founded Aligarh (as the school came to be known) on the model of Cambridge University. The school taught classes in English and combined Western and Islamic subjects within a single curriculum. Sayyid Ahmad wrote in a letter at the time:

> *The adoption of the new system of education does not mean the renunciation of Islam. It means its protection. The truth of Islam will shine the more brightly if its followers are well educated, familiar with the highest in the knowledge of the world, it will come under an eclipse if its followers are ignorant (De Bary 1958, 745).*

Unlike Deoband, Aligarh's students were drawn from the wealthier Muslim landlord and service communities of northern India.

Aligarh's "reformist" religious attitudes, however, placed it and its founder in opposition to contemporaneous pan-Islamic movements from the Middle East. In the 1880s one pan-Islamicist, Jamal al-Din al-Afghani, lived and lectured in both Calcutta and Hyderabad. al-Afghani's movement stressed the role of the Ottoman sultan as supreme leader of a worldwide Muslim community. In his speeches al-Afghani argued for Hindus and Muslims to unite against the British in India and

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abroad a position the Deobandis found attractive and British government officials alarming. Aligarh had always received considerable government funding. Sayyid Ahmad's pro-British views had led the British to hope that the school would develop a new (pro-British) Muslim elite that would dominate Indian Muslim communities. In the 1880s the British further raised their economic support for the college and this was one of the factors that led Aligarh to become the premier English language institution for Muslim Indian students in India.

Arya Samaj

The North Indian religious reform association, the Arya Samaj, was founded in 1875 in Bombay and in 1877 in the Punjab. It shared many of the same reform concerns as the Bengal and Bombay associations but added to these an aggressive, militant stance in relation to other North Indian religions. Dayananda Sarasvati, (1824–83), the society's founder, was a Gujarati sannyasi (holy man) with little interest in English education. In his early career Dayananda dressed and lived as a holy man, spoke in Sanskrit, and debated orthodox Hindu priests. After a trip to Calcutta in 1872 during which he met Debendranath Tagore and other Brahmos, Dayananda abandoned his mendicant clothing and began speaking in Hindi, a language that allowed him to reach an audience of Western-educated professionals and trading communities (Jones 1989).

His teachings resonated with these groups, particularly in the Punjab and northern Indian regions where followers nicknamed him the 'Luther of India'. Dayananda traveled these regions debating competing religionists (Muslims, Sikhs, or Hindu Sanatanists, that is, orthodox Hindus). He based his 'purified' Hinduism on the Sanskrit Vedas and rejected the popular Puranas, polytheism, idolatry, caste exclusivity, and customary restrictions on women. In Dayananda's Hinduism, *jati* (local caste divisions) should be replaced by a *varna* system that would be fixed for boys and girls 'according to merits and actions' (Jaffrelot 1996: 14).

In the 20th century both the Brahmo Samaj and the Prarthana Samaj remained focused on religious and cultural reform and subsequently declined in influence and membership. In contrast, the Arya Samaj switched its focus from reform and education to Hindu revivalism and nationalism and remained a vital and popular movement.

Theosophical Society

The theosophist movement of the late 19th century was also a religious reform society, but one that drew its membership primarily from

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Europeans and Americans. The society was founded in New York City in 1875 by a Russian, Helena Petrovna Blavatsky, and an American, Colonel Henry Steel Olcott. The society's religious ideas were originally drawn from Jewish mysticism and Western occultist movements. In 1879, Madame Blavatsky traveled to India to meet Swami Dayananda Sarasvati, whose Arya Samaj movement greatly interested her. Within a few years the society based its religious ideas on Hindu and Buddhist concepts of karma and reincarnation. Madame Blavatsky established the Indian headquarters of the Theosophist Society in Madras in 1882.

The Women's Question

Throughout the second half of the 19th century, the "women's question" encompassed a set of concerns debated in many Indian forums. For British critics, Indian women's social conditions demonstrated the backwardness and decadence of Indian civilization. In public meetings and tracts, Western-educated Indian men debated the need to reform practices such as the early age of marriage (child marriage), the seclusion of women (purdah), the ban on widow remarriage, and the Hindu religion's prohibition against women's literacy and education. At the same time, young Western-educated Indian men read *Romeo and Juliet* in college classes and often wrote passionately of their desire for romantic love and companionate marriage.

Both to reform women's social conditions and to create wives more to their liking, young English-educated men founded numerous societies for women's social reform and education during the second half of the 19th century. Women's education grew rapidly in this period among urban elites. In the mid-19th century, provinces such as Bengal had had only a small number of girls in school, but by the 20th century education was an accepted part of an urban middle-class girl's life. Many customary practices regarding women had changed or been adapted in urban and middle-class families. The age of marriage had risen, women appeared more frequently in public, and even widow remarriage had become marginally acceptable, especially for child widows, that is, girls whose husbands had died before the marriage was consummated. Two million girls were in schools in 1927, a small percentage of the total population of women but nevertheless a dramatic increase. Women's education was now identified with the general progress of Indian society. "Educating a girl," said one early 20th-century reformer, "means educating a family" (Chanana 1988, 97).

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The Dance of the Emancipated Bengalee Lady by Gaganendranath Tagore, ca. 1918. Gaganendranath Tagore (1867–1938), was born at Jorasanko, the Tagore mansion in north Calcutta, and was the nephew of Rabindranath Tagore. Well known as an artist, cartoonist, and social critic, Tagore drew several versions of this cartoon. He titled this version Colour Scream, noting "the times are changed and we are changed with them" and drawing his very liberated Indian lady dancing with a rather red- and pig-faced English dancing partner. (Chandi Lahiri)

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A GUJARATI WOMAN'S JOURNAL

The new wives desired by young Western educated men in the late 19th century were to be modern, literate and educated. Equally important they were to bring new domestic skills to family and home life. During the late 19th and early 20th centuries many domestic magazines and manuals appeared in North Indian languages, specifically addressed to women (both Hindu and Muslim) and written to teach women the new skills needed for modern home management, cooking, account keeping, child care, hygiene and married life. The manuals and magazines of the 19th century were almost all written or edited by English educated Indian men, but by the 20th century Indian women had taken over the production of these materials. The Gujarati-language journal *Stribodh* (Enlightenment of women) published from 1857 well into the 20th century, was part of this domestic literature. *Stribodh* encouraged women to use their leisure reading for domestic and self-improvement. Its issues profiled 'An Inspiring Woman' (for example Queen Victoria or Florence Nightingale) and offered instructions on sewing, embroidery and drawing, advice on how to purchase and arrange furniture, how to hire servants, how to use Western eating utensils, and on the moral benefits of reformed practices like the wearing of shoes and socks. Of special concern was how a wife cared for a husband when he returned home after a hard day at the office. Here are a few of *Stribodh*'s suggestions:

i. Arrange the house neatly and aesthetically.
ii. Keep the children neat and disciplined.
iii. Do not shout at children or beat them.
iv. Dress in nice clothes especially to receive him when he returns home in the evening.
v. Manage the servants well but do not mix with them.
vi. Never sit idle.
vii. Do not sit with other women to gossip and make idle talk.
viii. Do not complain to your husband about your children, mother-in-law, and sisters-in-law.
ix. Do not complain to him about your problems in household management.
x. Sing or play a musical instrument to help your husband relax when he returns home.
xi. Speak to him in a soft and pleasant manner.
xii. Do not ever nag him. (Shukla 1991, 65)

Source: Shukla, Sona. "Cultivating Minds: 19th Century Gujarati Women's Journals." *Economic and Political Weekly*, 26 October, 1991, p. 65.

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Rural India

Even as British rule reshaped Indian towns and cities and the urban Westernized Indian elite explored the ideas and practices of colonial modernity, in the Indian countryside a much larger population struggled to deal with the consequences of higher land revenues, a more commercially oriented agriculture, famine, and disease. India was a rural and agricultural society throughout the 19th and 20th centuries. In 1901 there were only 2,130 towns and cities in British India. India's total population was 284 million, and villages held 90 percent of those people.

Although records for 19th-century village life are limited, scholars think villages were populated by multiple castes and subcastes in the north and in the south by castes and subcastes that identified primarily with the Brahman or the Shudra *varna*. Religious and social relations in northern villages were structured through local castes and subcastes' *varna* identifications. Hereditary service relationships, called *jajmani* relations, bound village service and subordinate castes to the dominant caste of a village, that is, to the caste community that owned the greatest amount of the land surrounding the village.

During the 19th century, the British land settlements redefined rural life for the purpose of revenue collection by awarding land ownership to select categories of Indian peasants. In permanent settlement regions, such as Bengal, land ownership was awarded on the basis of prior zamindar (tax collector) status; in later settlements (particularly in south India), on the basis of land cultivation (*ryotwari*, or peasant, cultivation). In both types of settlement, however, landholdings became further subdivided over time, either as a result of divisions due to inheritance or because landowners subleased their lands to subordinate cultivators. Further, by the 20th century, if not earlier, large numbers of peasant households both owned land and worked as tenants on other families' lands. In the 1950s, when the first direct surveys of land control were done, 75 percent of rural households held less than five acres of land, and 23 percent owned no land at all.

Below village landowners, partial landowners, and tenants was the poorest rural class, the landless laborer. These workers had no rights in lands and survived only by working the lands of others. These workers and their families were often desperately poor. In 1881 one British official noted that this class permanently lacked sufficient food. By some estimates, landless laborers and their families numbered more than 52 million in 1901, almost 20 percent of the total Indian population. They came mostly from lower caste and tribal communities.

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Commercialization of Agriculture, 1860–1920

During the second half of the 19th century Indian rural products became increasingly integrated into global markets and Indian peasants shifted to growing raw materials for export to these markets. Peasant proprietors had an absolute need for cash funds both to pay land revenues and sometimes to buy seed crops. Money lenders, whether locals or outsiders (such as Marwari traders said to have come originally from Rajasthan), were the peasants' only source of funds. Local food crops grown for exchange within the village economy were less attractive than the commercial export crops—cotton, jute, wheat, oilseeds, tea, indigo, opium—that could be grown for cash.

From the 1860s to the 1920s the commercialization of agriculture reshaped rural India, altering the crops planted as well as patterns of rural relationships. Agriculture expanded from 1881 to 1931, and the number of agricultural workers rose 28 percent. But peasant economies growing crops for export could now also be destroyed by fluctuating world markets, and both rural indebtedness and loss of land became major rural problems in this period. During the 1860s and 1870s, for instance, the worldwide shortage of cotton caused by the American Civil War encouraged Indian peasants to increase cotton plantings. When the Civil War ended and cotton from the U.S. South reentered the world market, prices for Indian-produced cotton plunged. In addition, as Indian farmers switched to export crops, they lowered their production of food crops, particularly of the millets and pulses that fed poorer people in their economies. Between the 1890s and the 1940s, commercial crops increased by 85 percent, but the overall production of food crops declined by almost 30 percent. More rigid contractual agreements and new transportation networks linking Indian regions and tying into a world market worked together to give local producers little flexibility in deciding where their crops would go.

Famine

Famine had been a regular feature of Indian life from at least the 12th century, usually caused by the failure or excess of monsoon rains and usually limited in impact to a single region. Severe famines had occurred during both the Delhi Sultanate and the Mughal Empire. Under East India Company rule, in 1769–70 a famine in Bengal killed one-quarter of the region's population.

From the 1860s into the early years of the 20th century, however, a new pattern of famine emerged in British India. The commercialization

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of Indian agriculture reduced supplies of locally consumed food crops at the same time as railroads and roads tied even remote hinterlands into the wider Indian economy. Fixed contracts moved crops out of a region for sale elsewhere regardless of local conditions and even as local shortages mounted. Famines that once had been local or regional now spread more widely, affecting food supplies and causing deaths across several regions or even the whole country. Infectious diseases, bubonic plague in the 19th century, influenza in the 20th, often followed in the wake of these mass famines, attacking populations already weakened by starvation.

The first of this new type of famine was the 1866–67 Orissa famine, a spreading series of food shortages and dearth that extended from the Ganges River valley down the eastern seacoast, well past Orissa, through the Madras Presidency and west into Hyderabad and Mysore. The Orissa famine caused 800,000 famine deaths and affected more than 3 million people. ("Famine deaths" are calculated by subtracting the number of deaths normally expected in a region or period from the number of deaths that occur.)

Orissa was followed over the next several decades by an almost continuous series of regional or multiregional famines. In 1868–70 a second famine caused 400,000 deaths in the western Ganges, Rajasthan, central India, and the northern Deccan. 1873–74 saw severe famine in Bengal and eastern India. 1875–76 in the Deccan. 1876–78 in the Ganges region and in the cities of Madras, Hyderabad, Mysore, and Bombay. At the end of the century two devastating India-wide famines occurred one after the other. The 1896–97 famine affected 96 million Indians and caused more than 5 million famine deaths; the 1899–1900 famine affected 60 million Indians, also causing 5 million deaths.

Initially the British Indian government attributed the increased famines to monsoon failures and bad weather and argued that government intervention would only make conditions worse. But during the viceroyalty of Edward Robert Bulwer-Lytton (Lord Lytton) in the late 1870s, public outcry in Great Britain forced some government intervention. In 1883 a more Liberal viceroy, George Frederick Samuel Robinson, Lord Ripon, passed the Famine Code, a series of regulations to guide government interventions in famines and food shortages. The code prescribed methods for the early determination of shortages, declaring states of scarcity and famine, and using railways and shipping to move grain into famine regions. By the early 20th century the Famine Code, in conjunction with more aggressive food relief and public health measures, had all but eliminated mass famine deaths from India.

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Rural Protests

After 1857 there was never again a regional uprising that threatened British dominance in India. Nevertheless, British land revenue pressures, peasant indebtedness, and widespread famines produced a series of smaller regional, tribal, communal, and caste uprisings during the second half of the 19th century. Before 1857 local uprisings were most likely to be organized by regional rulers, chiefs, or zamindars dispossessed by an expanding British authority. After 1857, however, surviving princes and zamindars became staunch supporters of the Raj. Rural rebellions and social protests, some of the most important of which are described below, came mostly from lower-caste and -class communities and were not always directed against the British.

Tribal Rebellions

Tribals, or Scheduled Tribes, were forest-dwelling communities linked by kinship rather than caste and found throughout the subcontinent wherever cultivated lands met unexploited forests. By the late 19th century tribals still made up perhaps 10 percent of the total Indian population. British laws gave land and tenancy rights to peasant farming populations that paid land revenues but not to tribal communities that used the forests for hunting and gathering or for shifting cultivation but paid no revenues for this use.

Throughout the 19th century the British government made repeated efforts to force the tribal communities of northeastern Bengal, Bihar, central India, Gujarat, and Madras into cultivation (and the payment of land taxes) wherever possible. Violent protests against these pressures from the 1830s to the 1920s came from the Santhals in northeastern India (1833), from Naikda tribes in Gujarat (1868), and from several different communities in Madras Presidency (1879–80, 1886, and 1900). The largest tribal uprising, however, was the 1899–1900 Ulgulan (great tumult) of the Munda tribespeople of southern Bihar. By the 1890s Munda traditional lands had been seized by Hindu migrants from the plains and encroached on by the British government itself. Birsa Munda (ca. 1874–1900), a sharecropper convert to Vaishnavism with some missionary education, became the leader of the Munda movement in 1899. Claiming to be a new prophet, Birsa Munda urged his followers to kill Hindus, Muslims, and Christians, telling them that the weapons of the British police would magically melt into water once fighting began. Between December 1899 and January 1900 the Birsaites attacked churches and police stations in Ranchi district before being

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captured and imprisoned. Birsa Munda himself died in jail, and 350 Mundas were tried, three of whom were hanged and 44 transported for life.

Moplah Rebellions

Along the Malabar Coast, a Muslim community called the Moplahs (Mappilas) had developed out of mid-seventh to ninth century Arab trading settlements. When the British took over the region in the early 19th century, they gave landlord rights to Hindu upper-caste groups. A series of violent conflicts between the Moplahs and their Hindu landlords erupted, occurring in 1836, 1854, 1882–83, 1896, and 1921. In these uprisings, small bands of Moplahs attacked high-caste Hindu landlords and moneylenders, desecrated temples, and led suicide attacks against local police.

Peasant Protests

Peasant groups in the Deccan and in eastern India used a combination of violence, mass meetings, and legal challenges to seek relief from high land revenues and rural indebtedness in the decades after 1870. In 1875 the Deccan was torn by riots following the fall of cotton prices after the American Civil War. Villagers facing bankruptcy and the loss of lands joined together in attacks on the Marwari moneylenders to whom they were in debt. One of the Deccan's worst famines followed on the heels of riots, and the combination drove many peasants into banditry. Vasudeo Balvant Phadke (1845–83), a Chitpavan Brahman petty clerk in Pune, led a multicaste *dacoit* (bandit) gang in this period. Phadke declared himself the new minister to Shivaji II, an 18th century descendant of Shivaji, and led a series of robberies to finance what he hoped would be a more general rebellion against the British. Captured in 1879, Phadke was sentenced to transportation for life and died four years later.

In eastern Bengal, Assam, and Bombay, peasant movements turned to organization and legal actions to protest the imposition of higher land revenues. In 1873 in Pabna district in eastern Bengal, prosperous peasants organized protest meetings, rent strikes, and legal challenges to fight zamindar rent increases. In two districts of Assam in 1893, village assemblies and local elites used rent strikes to protest higher revenue settlements. In the region surrounding Bombay city, the famine of 1896–97 led to the looting of grain stores and to general demands for the remission of revenues. When the Bombay government refused these

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demands, a Pune political association, the Sarvajanik Sabha sent representatives out to the villages to inform peasants of their rights to rent remissions under British famine law. In the later famine of 1899–1903 "no revenue" movements also appeared in Surat and Ahmedabad.

Jyotirao Phule's Non-Brahman Movement

Not all protest was anti-British however. In 1873 Jyotirao Phule (1827–90), whose family was part of a relatively prosperous but low in status *mali* (gardener) caste in Pune, founded the Satyashodhak Samaj (Truth Seeking Society), an organization whose purpose was to unify the lower castes. Having completed his secondary education in English at a Pune school run by missionaries of the Free Church of Scotland, Phule read works on the lives of Shivaji II and the first U.S. president, George Washington, as well as the writings of the 18th century revolutionary Thomas Paine. He wanted to bring together what he called the *bahujan samaj*, the masses, the multitude, to free them from upper caste oppression. In Phule's reading of Indian history, the low castes and Untouchables, the original inhabitants of India, had been forced into "Brahmin thralldom" by invading foreign Aryans (Jaffrelot 2003: 153). For Phule the British were liberators, come to India to free "the disabled Sudras from the slavery of the crafty Aryas" (Wolpert 1962: 7). Phule's movement developed into a 20th century Marathi protest movement that was village based and anti-Brahman.

Second Afghan War, 1878–1880

The small revolts in the Indian interior that occurred after the 1857 rebellion could be easily contained by police and armies. But in the 1870s slow Russian advances into the Central Asian region of Turkistan renewed the fears of British officials in London that Russia might attack India through the Afghan country to the northwest. To ensure a sympathetic Afghan regime, the viceroy, Lord Lytton, deposed the Afghan ruler Sher Ali in 1878, replacing him with one of his sons, Yakub Khan. However in September 1879 the British political resident and his entire staff were massacred at Kabul in a popular uprising. British armies retaliated with great brutality. The cost and the violence of the war provoked public opposition in Great Britain. With the fall of the Conservative government and the appointment of the Liberal Lord Ripon as viceroy, the Indian government sued for peace. They supported Abdur Rahman Khan, a nephew of the deposed Sher Ali,

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as emir (ruler) of Kabul, providing him with an annual subsidy on the sole condition that he have no relations with any foreign powers except Great Britain. By 1881 Abdur Rahman had gained control over all of Afghanistan, which he ruled until his death in 1901. (In 1919 a third, one-month war forced the British to concede the Afghans' rights to conduct their own foreign relations.)

Vernacular Press Act

To forestall Indian public criticism over the expenses of the Second Afghan War, Lord Lytton's government passed the Vernacular Press Act of 1878. The act required Indian-language presses (but not those that published in English) to post bonds for their conduct with the government, with the clear threat that such bonds would be forfeited if what the presses published displeased the government. The act provoked angry objections from both press owners and their Indian readers. It became the occasion for political organizing in Calcutta, Pune, and Bombay, where newly formed political associations arranged protests and wrote petitions demanding its repeal. At a public meeting in Pune to oppose the act, speakers from the Sarvajanik Sabha (Public Association) denounced the act for infringing on that "freedom of thought and speech [which] is a right to which all subjects of the British Crown are entitled by their birth and allegiance" (Wolpert 1962, 12).

Regional Political Associations

By 1878 politics was a major interest of urban Indian elites. Indians began forming regional political associations in the late 1860s and early 1870s. The religious or social reform associations of the century focused inward on questions internal to indigenous Indian society: religious practices, women's social conditions, caste interactions. Political associations, in contrast, looked outward, focusing their activities on the policies and actions of the British Indian government.

English-educated Indians organized their regional political associations along modern lines, using contemporary political forms and practices, and framed their concerns using the language and concepts of British constitutional democracy. Political associations elected officers, collected dues and subscriptions, kept minutes of their activities, and held Town Hall meetings to debate and publicize their issues. They petitioned regional governments on issues of concern to English-educated and middle-class communities that supported them. Key issues were

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access to ICS (civil service) examinations, broader (middle-class) Indian participation in the governments Legislative Councils, the excessive expenses of the Afghan wars, and government inaction during famines.

Pune

One of the earliest and most successful of the regional associations was Pune's Sarvajanik Sabha. Founded in 1870 out of several smaller groups, Pune's political association regularly organized public meetings, debates, protests, and petitions on the issues of the day. It provided an early and regional context for the political development of three of India's most famous nationalist leaders.

The three men were Mahadev Govind Ranade (1842–1901), a leader of the Prarthana Samaj in Bombay; Gopal Krishna Gokhale (1866–1915); and Balwantrao Gangadhar Tilak (1856–1920). All came from Maharashtra, from the elite Chitpavan Brahman community, and all three were English educated, Ranade and Gokhale at Elphinstone College in Bombay and Tilak first at Pune's local Deccan College and then later at Elphinstone. Ranade, the eldest of the three, was a lawyer and judge, college teacher, historian, and above all, social reformer. He founded in 1887 the National Indian Social Conference. Gokhale, Ranade's disciple, was a founding member of Pune's Fergusson College, where he taught for 20 years. He was committed to secular social reform, founding the Servants of India Society in 1905, an organization of full-time volunteers dedicated to welfare work. In contrast, Tilak was the editor and publisher of two popular Pune newspapers, the English language *Mahratta* and the Marathi language *Kesari* (Lion). In his newspapers and speeches, Tilak rejected the idea of social reform. He preferred to direct his energies toward the revival of Hinduism and the use of Hindu religious images and festivals for political organizing in the region. Over the years, from the 1870s until their deaths in the 20th century, the two younger men, Gokhale and Tilak, fought out their opposing views—first on social reform and religion, later on politics—both within Pune's Sarvajanik Sabha and later on the national stage.

Bombay

In Bombay city, the English educated came from commercial and trading communities, one of the most visible of which was the Parsis. Descended from 10th-century Zoroastrian migrants from Iran, the Bombay Parsis had been early supporters of English language education. Their most famous member in the 19th century, and one of India's

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earliest nationalist writers was Dadabhai Naoroji (1825–1917). Naoroji was an early graduate of Elphinstone College who had founded one of the first Indian business firms in London and Liverpool in the 1850s. Traveling frequently between England and India, he wrote on British-Indian economic relations and became a mentor in England to Indian boys sent abroad for education. In the 1890s he became the first Indian elected to the British Parliament. Another politically prominent Parsi was Pherozeshah Mehta (1845–1915), a prominent Bombay lawyer. Mehta began his long career in regional and national politics in the late 1870s, when he was drawn into local efforts to protest the Vernacular Press Act. He and other members of Bombay's urban elite formed a local political association, the Bombay Presidency Association, in 1885.

Madras

In the 19th and early 20th centuries Madras Brahmans dominated the local English-educated community and local Brahman communities



Annie Besant, shown here in a sari on a street in India, 1926. Annie Wood Besant (1847–1933) had been the wife of an Anglican clergyman and associate of an English atheist and social reformer before she converted to theosophy in 1889 and moved to Madras (now Chennai), India. Besant, who was the international president of the Theosophical Society from 1907 until her death, lived at the society's headquarters in Madras and lectured and wrote extensively on theosophy and on educational and humanitarian issues in India. She became a strong supporter of Indian independence, founding the Home Rule League during World War I and serving as the first woman president of the India National Congress in 1917. (Library of Congress)

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competed for control over the city's political activities. G. Subramaniya Ayyar and M. Viraghava Chana, joint publishers of the leading Madras newspaper, the *Hindu*, initially founded a local political association, the Madras Native Association, in 1878. When disagreements split that association during the 1883–84 Ilbert Bill controversy, the original founders reformed it as the Madras Mahajana Sabha (Great Peoples Association). Madras politics were further complicated after 1893 when the English Socialist Annie Besant (1847–1933) moved to the city. Besant, who became the Theosophical Society's president in 1907, actively involved herself in regional and national politics on the side of Indian political self-determination.

Calcutta

Bengal was home to what was probably the oldest political association in the country. The British Indian Association was a loyalist organization of princes, zamindars, and later industrialists, founded in the 1840s. In 1875 a new political organization, the Indian League, was founded by members of the English-educated Bengali community who worked in the city's new professions of law, education, and journalism. After a year, it was supplanted by the newly formed Indian Association, founded by Surendranath Banerjea (1848–1926), a former ICS officer who had been fired from the service and had turned instead to college teaching and journalism. Under Banerjea's leadership the Indian Association aggressively pursued public issues of interest to its members, among other things helping to organize a multiregional protest by Indian elites against the 1878 Vernacular Press Act.

The Ilbert Bill

The return of a Liberal government to power in Britain had brought the marquis of Ripon to India as viceroy in 1880. Ripon began his term in a mode popular with Westernized Indians by repealing the Vernacular Press Act of 1878. He also encouraged the growth of primary and secondary schools and created governing boards in municipalities and districts that elected two-thirds of their members. But in 1883 he aroused the fury of the Anglo-Indian community when his law member, Sir Courtney Ilbert, proposed modifying an 1873 law to allow certain cases involving Europeans to be tried by Indian judges. At well-organized public meetings and in newspaper ads, the Anglo-Indian community declared the Ilbert Bill "intensely distasteful, and humiliating to all

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Europeans' (Metcalf and Metcalf 2006: 120). In blunter language, Anglo-Indian associations denounced the idea that "nigger natives" could be considered their "peers or equals" (Wolpert 1989: 257). In 1884 Ripon's government gave in and amended the bill to mandate that if a European's case was to be tried by an Indian judge, his jury must be at least half Europeans. For Anglo-Indians this was a great victory. For Westernized Indians, both the process and the resolution demonstrated the fundamental racism of Anglo-Indians and the Indian government in which they served. The bill also demonstrated to the Indian elite the power and effectiveness of organized public protest.

By the time of the Ilbert Bill controversy, British rule in India had transformed many aspects of Indian society. The British Raj had introduced British administrative structures and the ideas and practices of the West to a newly forming urban Indian elite. British economic structures had transformed Indian agricultural production even as government subsidized railroads and roads bound the subcontinent more tightly together. In rural India, these changes left peasants more vulnerable than ever both to the economic fluctuations of the global marketplace and to the spread of calamitous famine and disease. In urban India, over the course of the 19th century, the new elites of British Indian towns and cities had adapted themselves to the office work, administrative structures, and Western practices of the British Raj; by the late 19th century these cities had begun to change their focus. From earlier preoccupations with religious and social reform, acculturation, and self-improvement, they now wrote and spoke more about the revival and protection of indigenous religion and culture, about finding ways to participate in India's imperially controlled government, and even about nationalism, independence, and *swaraj* (self-rule).

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6

TOWARD FREEDOM (1885–1920)

This is the first and most essential thing to learn about India—that there is not, and never was an India, or even any country of India, possessing, according to European ideas, any sort of unity, physical, political, social or religious. That men of the Punjab, Bengal, the North Western Provinces and Madras should ever feel that they belong to one great Indian nation, is impossible.

■

Sir John Strachey, India, 1888 (Embree 1972, 3)

The men who participated in the Indian nationalist movement from its beginnings in the Indian National Congress in 1885 to Mohandas Gandhi's assumption of leadership in the 1920s all came from the English-educated elite. They agreed broadly on the issues that most affected them as a class—the need for greater access to the ICS and for middle-class appointments to the Legislative Councils—and they agreed on the terrible effects of the drain of Indian wealth to Great Britain. But on the questions of whether the nationalist movement should work for social reform or Hindu revivalism or whether its members should see themselves as Her Majesty's loyal opposition or as freedom fighters, they had no such easy answers. Early nationalists spent as much energy fighting one another over these matters as they did in fighting the British.

In the decades between 1885 and 1920, in response to nationalist pressures, British rulers offered a series of constitutional concessions, giving Indians marginal participation in India's government while conceding as little real power as possible. At the same time, British officials worked to "divide and rule." To preserve British power, officials encouraged minority constituencies to define themselves in opposition

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to one another as Muslims against Hindus, Dravidians against Aryans or Untouchables against Brahmans.

In the end, however, despite all their efforts, it was the British themselves who brought about the unity of Indian nationalists. Unbridled demonstrations of imperial power and British racism in both 1905 and in 1919 brought elite urban Indians not only into unity but looking outside their own elite class for broader support for their movement against the British.

The Indian National Congress

In December 1885, 73 mostly self-appointed delegates from all over British India met in Bombay for a three-day conference. This was the first meeting of the Indian National Congress. It had originally been scheduled to meet in Pune, for Ranade and Pune's Sarvajanik Sabha were among its leading organizers, but an outbreak of cholera forced its relocation to Bombay. Its delegates represented every province of British India. 54 delegates were Hindu, most of whom were Brahman; two delegates were Muslim, and the rest came from the Parsi or Jain communities. All were English-educated. Congress, as it came to be called, began its existence as a supraregional political association, a three-day yearly forum through which middle-class Indian men could petition and memorialize the Indian government, just as regional associations had already been doing, but now on a wider basis.

The immediate impetus for the meeting came from Allan Octavian Hume (1829–1912), a retired ICS official, who believed, as he told the viceroy Frederick Hamilton Temple Blackwood, Lord Dufferin (1826–1902), that such a gathering would stabilize the English-educated elite. Hume helped organize the first meeting of Congress, circulating letters to English-educated graduates to encourage their support and serving as its first secretary. But many Congress attendees already knew or knew of each other before the first meeting. Surendranath Banerjea, W. C. Bonnerji (the first Congress president), Romeshchandra Dutt, Pherozeshah Mehta, and Badruddin Tyabji had all come under the influence of Dadabhai Naoroji while in England in the 1860s and 1870s. Leaders of regional political associations in Pune, Bombay, Madras, and Calcutta knew of each other from shared protests against the 1878 Vernacular Press Act. And Banerjea's Indian Association had already organized two national conferences, one in 1883 and one held at the same time as the Bombay meeting in 1885.

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Until Gandhi reorganized it in the 1920s the Indian National Congress met for only three days each year, each meeting organized by members from the region in which it was held. It had limited funds and for its first nine years its only full-time officer was Hume, its general secretary. In its first years Congress grew quickly from 73 delegates in 1885 to 600 in 1887 and almost 2,000 in 1889. Through Hume's efforts Muslim participation grew to almost 14 percent of the delegates by 1887. Attendance at the 1887 and 1888 sessions was particularly broad based, with more than half the delegates traveling to the meeting from outside the region in which it was held.

Congress delegates came from every British Indian province and spoke many dialects, but they shared the elite status and high caste background common to the English-educated elite. They agreed (as did the English-educated generally) that Indians needed greater access to the ICS and that middle-class Indians should serve on the government's Legislative Councils. The ICS was the premier service in India; appointment within the civil service gave Indians the only direct governmental power they could have in British India. ICS appointments were chosen by open competitive examinations, but the exams were held only in England, and the maximum age for examinees (in 1876) was 19. As late as 1880 the 900-member ICS had only 16 Indians. In a similar way the Legislative Councils also offered Indian members a voice, if not in government decisions, at least in the debates that preceded them. But while the councils had had appointed Indian members since the 1860s, in practice only Indian princes and zamindars were ever nominated.

Seven successive years of Congress oratory and petitions succeeded in 1892 in having the maximum age for taking the ICS exams raised to 23. In the same year the Indian Councils Act provided for indirect elections to the central and regional Legislative Councils in Bengal, Bombay, and Madras. Through an elaborate procedure, local municipal boards, universities, and landowners' associations (among others) submitted lists of elected representatives to the government for final selection. Nevertheless, the process brought prominent regional leaders such as Banerjea and Tilak onto their respective regional councils and moderate Congress members, such as Mehta and Gokhale, onto the central Legislative Council. Despite constant Indian pressure, however, the ICS examinations, the key to Anglo-Indian dominance within the service, would not be held in India until the 1920s.

While Congress petitions on English-educated issues brought some limited success, escalating conflicts between social reformers and religion revivalists split the English-educated elite in the 1890s, and violent

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THE DRAIN

From the perspective of British imperialists, all the expenses of the British Empire in India went toward services and projects that improved India itself. "England receives nothing from India," wrote Sir John Strachey, "except in return for English services rendered or English capital expended." (Sarkar 1983, 27). But for Indian nationalists nothing was farther from the truth. Against the backdrop of the widespread famines, sickness, and poverty of late 19th-century rural India, nationalist leaders such as Dadabhai Naoroji and Romeshchandra Dutt put forth their economic theory of "the drain."



Dadabhai Naoroji was from the Parsi community of Bombay, now Mumbai. He was educated at Elphinstone College in that city before traveling abroad to England where he established himself in business and even won election to Parliament in 1892. Naoroji mentored many Indian students who traveled to England to study in the late 19th century, and his economic theories about the British Empire—especially his theory of "the drain"—shaped the views of several generations of Indian nationalists. (R. P. Patwardhan, ed. Dadabhai Naoroji Correspondence, Vol. 2, Part 1. Correspondence with D. E. Wacha, 1977)

Far from benefiting India, they argued, British rule was draining India's wealth away from her. Yearly home charges (funds sent to Great Britain) drained revenues from India to pay for the high salaries and pensions of British civil servants in India and for the exorbitant expenses of an Indian army used by Great Britain throughout the world. British rule, said nationalist economists, had replaced a prosperous, indigenous Indian economy with an imperial economic network that benefited foreigners (and Great Britain itself) at the expense of indigenous Indians.

Modern scholars have continued to debate "the drain." Some argue that railroads, technology, and export agriculture benefited India's economy in the end. Others assert that the

(continues)

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THE DRAIN *(continued)*

British Empire drained off as much as 4 percent of India's national income in the later decades of the 19th century (Tomlinson 1993, 14)

Sources: Sarkar, Sumit. *Modern India 1885–1947* (Madras: Macmillan India, 1983), p. 27; Tomlinson, B. R. *The Economy of Modern India, 1860–1970* (Cambridge and New York: Cambridge University Press, 1993), p. 14

communal clashes divided the broader Indian society. These conflicts took their toll on Indian political associations. Interest in both Congress and regional political associations declined in the 1890s, and Muslim attendance at Congress sessions was cut almost in half. Annual Congress meetings began attracting fewer delegates from outside the state where they were held and making up the difference with more local members.

Hindu Race/Hindu Nation

As was true of much of 19th-century society, early Indian nationalists imagined "the nation" using two different and often contradictory sets of ideas and images. One strand of 19th-century thought conceived of the nation in terms of citizenship and constitutionalism. Nations, in this view, were composed of individual citizens living within a territorial state, their political obligations and rights defined by a constitutional contract between each citizen and that state. Congress and regional political leaders known collectively to their contemporaries as the "moderates"—men such as Ranade, Gokhale, Mehta, or Banerjea—advanced this concept of the nation, citizenship, and constitutionalism. They spoke the language of British constitutional democracy and presented themselves as the government's "loyal opposition"—as leaders of India's citizenry struggling to obtain for them their inalienable rights.

Comfortable themselves with a style of life, dress, and habits adapted to British colonial public life, these leaders enjoyed their new elected or appointed positions within British government and their status within elite urban Indian society. They looked forward to middle-class Indians making gradual gains in influence and power within British-ruled India but were not troubled by the idea that such gains might be far into the future. They frequently—if not always—supported social reforms,

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THE SCIENCE OF NOSES

The leading exponent of race science in India was H. H. Risley (1851–1911), a British ethnologist who served in India in the Indian Civil Service from 1873 to 1910. Risley was the census commissioner in 1901 and after his retirement in 1910 he was elected president of the (British) Royal Anthropological Institute. Following the anthropometric techniques of the French anthropologist Paul Topinard, Risley used a 'nasal index' (a ratio of the width of a nose to its height) to divide Indians into two races: a dark-skinned Dravidian race and a fair-skinned Indo-Aryan race. Using this nose science he proved (to his own satisfaction and that of contemporaries) the existence of a seven-caste racial hierarchy in India, with Dravidians at the "primitive" bottom and Indo-Aryans at the "civilized" top. "The social position of a caste," he once said, "varies inversely as its nasal index" (Trautmann). Race, not occupation, he concluded was the true basis of the Indian caste system. For late 19th-century "race scientists" such as Risley, this type of physiological measurements served to confirm the distinct racial essences they believed existed within the Indian population (and more generally in the larger world).



The "science" of noses. H. H. Risley drew his ideas on nose measurements from the work of a contemporary 19th-century French scholar, Paul Topinard. Writing in his 1885 Elements of General Anthropology (Elements d'anthropologie générale), Topinard developed a "nasal index" (a ratio of the breadth of the nose to its height) that enabled him to classify noses (and their owners) into a series of nose types. Narrow noses, said Topinard, characterized the Europeans (types 1 through 5); medium noses characterized the "yellow races" (type 6); and broad noses belonged either to Africans (type 7) or to Melanesians and native Australians (type 8). — Paul Topinard, *Elements d'anthropologie générale*, 1885)

Source: Trautmann, Thomas R. *Aryans and British India* (New Delhi: Vistaar, 1997), p. 203.

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these would, as they saw it, modernize Indian society, ridding it of the degraded practices of the past.

But there was a second way of imagining "the nation" current in the 19th century world. Nationhood, as social anthropologist Susan Bayly has pointed out, "was widely regarded both in India and elsewhere as an expression of collective moral, spiritual, and racial essences" (1999, 156). This second view conceived of the nation as a unit bound together by racial ties of blood and ethnic ties of culture. The language of race itself was in constant use in whatever was said or written in this period about Indian communities. Writers frequently referred to the Hindu or "Mohammedan" races and ranked of castes (*varnas* or *jatis*) as racial entities. Both Westernized social reformers and Hindu cultural revivalists used "race" without self-consciousness to describe the deeper ties that might bind a religion, a caste, or a regional community together. Ranade could describe how social reforms would benefit the "chosen race" of the Hindus as easily as Arya Samajis could describe the rituals through which Muslims and/or Untouchables might reenter the "Aryan race" (Bayly 1999, 175).

By the late 19th century the linkage of "race" and "nation" was commonplace, with both British and Indians referring interchangeably to an Aryan or Hindu "race" or an Aryan or Hindu "nation." But at the turn of the century some Indian leaders, beginning with Tilak in Pune, began to place this more general sense of a Hindu race/nation in a deliberately and more explicitly political context, linking anticolonial protests to a Hindu communal identity through the religious language and symbols of Hinduism. Contemporaries labeled Tilak, along with such men as Lajpat Rai (1865–1928) in the Punjab and Bipin Chandra Pal (1858–1932) in Bengal, as "extremists," not for their evocation of a Hindu cultural identity, but because they questioned the inevitability of Indian self-government and were willing to use a variety of means, including violence, to bring Indians closer to self-rule.

Hindu Revivalism

Up to the 1890s Western educated Indians had supported social and religious reforms. They founded movements such as the Brahmo Samaj in Bengal or the early Arya Samaj in North India and used such organizations to move contemporary caste practices and Hindu customs regarding women's education and social behavior closer to the norms of British colonial modernity. But at the turn of the century, even as such adaptations became well integrated into middle-class urban lifestyles, a

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RAMAKRISHNA AND VIVEKANANDA

The Hindu saint Sri (meaning 'respected') Ramakrishna (1836–86) was a Brahman priest at a temple of the goddess Kali in north Calcutta. Ramakrishna had little formal education and could read and write only in Bengali. He attained mystical ecstasies by worshipping the goddess through a variety of religious forms and idioms, as the Mother Goddess, as Krishna, as Muhammad, and as Jesus Christ. Discovered by the Brahmo Samaj leader Keshab Sen, Ramakrishna became popular among young men from Calcutta's Indian elite in the 1870s and 1880s. To these Westernized followers Ramakrishna's mystic bhakti (devotion) to the Mother Goddess was more vibrant than the Westernized worship of Brahmo 'churches.' Ramakrishna's religious teachings and mystical experiences seemed to demonstrate the "oneness" of all religions and the inherent superiority of a Hinduism that could acknowledge this universality.

Narendranath Datta (1863–1902) was one of the middle-class men who visited Ramakrishna in his temple. Narendranath came from a family of Calcutta lawyers, was Western educated, and had joined the Brahmo Samaj. He was planning to study law abroad when he first went to visit Ramakrishna in 1882. By 1886, the year of the saint's death, Narendranath had dedicated himself to the life of a religious holy man, a *sannyasi*. Under the name Vivekananda, he became Ramakrishna's best-known disciple. In 1893 in a famous speech at the First World Parliament of Religions in Chicago, Vivekananda spoke of Hinduism as the mother of all religions, a religion that could recognize and incorporate within itself the truths of all religions. Vivekananda saw his religious movement as a contemporary form of Vedanta. His Chicago speech gained him an international audience that kept him traveling and lecturing in the United States and England for the next four years. Returning to India in 1897, he founded the Ramakrishna Mission in Calcutta, an institution of Hindu monks dedicated to Ramakrishna's religious insights and teachings and to social service.

renewed interest emerged in what contemporaries called "Hindu revivalism," that is, the maintenance of extant Hindu beliefs and practices and the defense of such practices from further erosion.

In Calcutta young English-educated men turned away from the "male" worship of the Brahmo Samaj churches to become fascinated with the

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mystic visions of Ramakrishna, a semi-illiterate priest in a north Calcutta temple. In novels and newspaper pieces writers discovered anew the inspiring bravery and devotion of the sati. Women's literature and manuals denounced the denaturalizing effect of higher education on women—for, as one manual writer noted in a common joke of the period, 'If a girl can become a bachelor, what else does she need to become a man?' (Gupta 1885: 23). The Arya Samaj had long stood uncompromisingly for social and religious reform in northern India. Now it split in the 1890s. One sect continued the old work of education and reform, but a second and larger group committed itself instead to the revival of the 'Aryan race', to the conversion of orthodox Hindus, Muslims, Sikhs, and Untouchables to the Samaj through new *shuddhi* (purification) ceremonies, to proselytizing for the use of Hindi and the Sanskritic Devanagari alphabet in north India, and the protection of the cow.

Cow Protection Riots

Cow protection riots, pitting Hindus against Muslims, occurred repeatedly across northern India during the 1880s and 1890s, from Bombay and Maharashtra in the west to Bengal in the east. The earliest riots were in the Punjab in 1883, followed by large-scale communal riots from 1888 to 1893 in the United Provinces, Bihar, Bengal, and even Rangoon. In 1893–94 violent riots broke out in the city of Bombay and in the wider Maharashtra region.

At issue was the Muslim slaughter of cows for meat, particularly as part of religious festivities such as Bakr Id (the festival in the last month of the Islamic calendar). Such slaughter demonstrated to Hindu revivalists how contemporary society failed to protect Hindu religious practices and the Hindu way of life. Linked with cow protection were campaigns to replace Urdu, written in the Perso-Arabic script, with Hindi written in the Sanskrit-based Devanagari script, and the Arya Samaj's use of 'purification' rituals to bring converts into the Arya Samaj fold.

The founder of the Arya Samaj, Dayananda Sarasvati, had himself written a pamphlet urging the protection of cows in 1881. From the late 1880s cow protection societies appeared among Hindu populations in northern India. These societies emphasized long-standing Hindu customs venerating the cow, held meetings protesting cow slaughter, and even petitioned the government to prohibit this slaughter on hygienic grounds. They were funded by a range of local elites, including zamindars, middle-class lawyers, and even, in Bombay, a Gujarati mill owner

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Regional politicians, such as Tilak in Bombay, helped organize such meetings and participated in their protests.

Bitter competition between local Hindu and Muslim elites for government employment helped fuel the communal riots that grew out of cow protection conflicts. In different regions class and cultural conflicts helped the violence to escalate. In the Punjab the cow protection riots built on long standing conflicts between Muslim peasants and Hindu traders and moneylenders. In the United Provinces multiple social tensions supported the riots: in rural regions conflicts between Muslim landlords and Hindu peasants and in urban towns between Hindu bankers and Muslim artisans and workers.

Cow protection conflicts merged easily with more general violence over religious festivals and processions. Although in prior decades Hindus and Muslims had participated in each others religious festivals, by the late 19th century the two communities were openly split along religious lines. "What boon has Allah conferred upon you," went one turn-of-the-century Maharashtrian song, "That you have become a Mussalman today? The cow is our mother, do not forget her" (Sarkar 1983, 60).

Age of Consent Act, 1891

Controversy over the 1891 Age of Consent Act gave public expression to the feelings of many middle-class Hindus that the protection of Hindu customs and a Hindu identity was now of much greater urgency than the reform of social customs. The immediate cause for the act was the death in Calcutta of an 11-year-old girl, Phulmoni Bai, from lacerations caused by intercourse with her 35-year-old husband. As the law set the age of statutory rape at 10 for girls, the husband could not be prosecuted. The Age of Consent Bill raised the age of statutory rape for girls from 10 to 12 years old. Although proposed by the government, the reform had long been sought by Indian reformers, and the act was supported by an Indian National Congress dominated by its moderate faction.

In both Bengal and western India, however, opposition to the bill was virulent. By custom Hindu marriages were consummated immediately following the wife's first menstruation. Under the bill, for girls who menstruated before the age of 12 the custom would now be criminalized. "The Hindu family is ruined," wrote *Bangabasi*, the conservative Bengali newspaper that spearheaded opposition in Calcutta (Sarkar 2002, 234). In west India, Tilak opposed the bill in his newspaper *Kesari*. In both regions opponents of the bill held mass meetings and

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sent petitions. In Pune young Hindu men broke up a meeting attended by social reformers and wrecked the hall in which they met.

The bill became law in 1891 despite substantial Indian opposition. In the aftermath of the controversy social reformers were vilified in Bengal and Bombay as Western turncoats who had betrayed their own religion. Every year since its founding in 1887 Ranades Indian National Social Conference had held its annual meetings at the same time as the Congress session and under Congress auspices. Now in 1895 Hindu revivalists threatened to boycott the next meeting of Congress if Ranades conference met under the Congress banner. To pacify the revivalists Ranades conference was barred from the session. Disagreements over social reform issues would not be allowed to divide the Congress. Congress would include, said its president Surendranath Banerjea, both "those who would reform their social customs and those who would not" (Wolpert 1989, 263).

Although they lost their struggle, opponents of the Age of Consent Bill still profited from their efforts. Bengali newspapers that supported the protests turned from weekly to daily papers on the strength of their increased circulation. In Pune, Tilak's opposition to the act made him a hero to lower middle-class Hindus in Deccan towns and *mofussil* regions and gained him increased financial support from wealthy Hindu conservatives.

The Marriage of Religion and Politics

The Age of Consent controversy showed Bal Gangadhar Tilak the role religion might play in political organizing. In the decade after 1891 Tilak and others organized two festivals that used Hindu religious icons and images for political ends. In 1893 a new festival began celebrating the birthday of the elephant-headed Hindu god Ganesh, and in 1895 a second festival celebrated the memory of Shivaji. Both festivals became Hindu community events, with songs, dances, scriptural readings, and (in the Shivaji celebration) a religious procession led by huge portraits of Shivaji and his Brahman guru. The Ganesh festival was deliberately timed to draw Hindus away from the Muslim festival of Mohurram, which both communities had previously celebrated. Both new festivals encouraged Hindus to see themselves as a distinct community, separate from Muslims or Christians. By 1895 Tilak's opposition to the Age of Consent Act combined with his role in organizing the new festivals had made his faction strong enough to take over Pune's political association, the Sarvajanik Sabha.

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Ganesh (Ganapati) Bhubaneswar Orissa Ganesh Ganapati in western India) is the elephant-headed son of the Hindu gods Shiva and Parvati He is widely worshipped throughout India as a god able to overcome (or to help his worshippers overcome) obstacles in life His image is frequently found installed in stores and businesses The celebration of Ganesh's birthday became a central religious political festival of western India beginning in the late 19th century (courtesy of Judith E Walsh

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Tilak encouraged his followers to use violence against social reformers, Muslims, and the British. He himself had ties to revolutionary societies now organized in Maharashtra. His supporters threw rocks at Pune social reformers; his followers paraded noisily in paramilitary fashion past Muslim mosques. In *Kesari* Tilak used references to the Bhagavad Gita to justify the use of violence, arguing that violence committed with no thought of gain or reward was not morally wrong. "Shrimat Krishna," he said in comments at the time of the Shivaji festival of 1897, "preached in the Gita that we have a right even to kill our own guru and our kinsmen. No blame attaches to any person if he is doing deeds without being actuated by a desire to reap the fruit of his deeds." (Wolpert 1962: 87).

In June 1897 bubonic plague spread through Maharashtra. Pune's plague commissioner, Walter Charles Rand, took drastic measures to combat it. Rand ordered British troops to fumigate and lime all houses where plague was suspected. The soldiers forced all inhabitants (including women in purdah) out of their homes and took anyone thought infected to an isolation camp outside the city. Often family members only saw their relatives when told to come and collect their dead bodies. The measures provoked fury among Pune's residents and failed to contain the plague. As the plague raged, Pune's Anglo-Indian elite organized an elaborate gala to celebrate Queen Victoria's jubilee. Two brothers, Damodar and Balkrishna Chapekar, assassinated Rand and one other officer as they left the celebrations. Both the Chapekar brothers were subsequently caught and hanged.

The brothers were followers of Tilak, and rumors linked him with the assassinations. Based on articles written for *Kesari*, Tilak was arrested in July and tried for sedition. The six Europeans on his jury found him guilty; the three Indians said he was innocent. Tilak was sentenced to 18 months' imprisonment in Bombay but released after one year on grounds of ill health. From this time on, Tilak acquired the unofficial title of "Lokamanya" (revered of the people).

Bengal Partition

If the Age of Consent controversy revealed deep divisions among elite Hindu communities, the British government's partition of Bengal in 1905 overrode many of those divisions. Bengal's partition provided the context for India's first national protest against British actions and united many in support of the nationalist cause.

The partition was planned during the 1899–1905 viceroyalty of George Nathaniel Curzon (1859–1925). In some ways Curzon was for

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tunate, taking office as new government procedures brought the 19th-century mass famines under control and as a more stable Indian rupee began to lower the growth rate of "home charges." During his term as viceroy Curzon oversaw the overhaul of government bureaucracy, the building of more than 6,000 miles of new railroad tracks, and the passage of several land measures designed to protect cultivators from eviction for debts, including the Punjab Land Alienation Act in 1901.

Curzon's imperious and autocratic character, however, created conflicts. His resignation in 1905 resulted from an internal political dispute in which he ultimately refused to follow orders from his superior in London, the secretary of state for India. His arrogance and racism made him contemptuous of English-educated Indians—he once called the Indian National Congress an "unclean thing"—and his government took a number of actions that antagonized elite Indians (Sarkar 1983, 104), including reducing the number of Indians on the municipal boards of cities and passing the Universities Act in 1904, a series of measures that tightened government controls over universities and their affiliated colleges in order to control student protests.

Curzon's most provocative government action, however, was undoubtedly the partition of Bengal. With 78.5 million people in 1901, Bengal was India's largest province and an unwieldy administrative unit (Schwartzberg 1992, 217). Its partition was planned for almost two years within Curzon's administration and formally announced in July 1905. The division created two provinces. One of approximately 38 million people was made by combining predominantly Muslim eastern Bengal with the smaller province of Assam. The second was a somewhat larger western province of almost 55 million people that merged Bengali-speaking regions north and west of Calcutta with Hindi-speaking Bihar and Oriya-speaking Orissa. One benefit of the plan, from the perspective of British officials, was that it offered Muslims a separate province in which they were a majority. A second advantage was that in both new provinces Bengali-speaking Hindus were in the minority, thus enabling the government, as one official wrote in a private memo, "to split up and thereby weaken a solid body of opponents to our rule" (Sarkar 1983, 107).

Swadeshi

British officials anticipated mass meetings and memorials to protest the division, but they were unprepared for the sustained political protest that occurred or for the new forms that protest took. Partition protests

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lasted several years spreading beyond Bengal to Bombay, the Punjab, and Madras and involving substantial numbers of English-educated students, professionals and their families. Initially even Congress moderates supported the protest although as violence broke out, they quickly withdrew their support. Antipartition leaders called for the boycott of British goods and the support of *swadeshi* (the native country's) products. Schools and shops closed. Public bonfires burned imported cotton goods. Schoolchildren sang "Bande Mataram" ("Hail to the motherland")—a slogan and song from an 1880s Bengali novel. Processions chanted the slogan and shouted out in unison the names of the three most popular extremists who led them: Lal, Bal, Pal—Lala Lajpat Rai from the Punjab, Bal Gangadhar Tilak from Pune, and Bipin Chandra Pal from Bengal. Terrorist cells sprang up in Bengal as they had in Maharashtra earlier and their members planted bombs and attempted the assassination of several British officials.

The *swadeshi* boycotts were surprisingly effective, demonstrating the degree to which Indian middle class tastes had already shaped British imports. By 1906 Calcutta customs officials had noted substantial decreases in imported products: a 22 percent decrease in cotton fabrics, a 44 percent decrease in cotton threads, a 50 percent fall in imported cigarettes, and a 68 percent drop in imported boots and shoes. By 1908 imports were down overall by 25 percent. Indian merchants and textile producers raised both prices and profits (Wolpert 2009, 285). In Bombay, the Tatas, a Parsi industrialist family loyal to the British, launched India's first indigenous steelworks, thus reducing the Indian government's need for imports of Belgian steel.

The government attempted to stop the protests by arresting middle-class students, banning public meetings, and imprisoning protest leaders. In London, the new Liberal government considered offering constitutional reforms in the hope that this would undercut further protest.

Muslim League

Whether and to what extent elite Muslims would join the Indian National Congress was an open question throughout the late 19th and early 20th centuries. As early as 1869 the prominent Muslim leader (and British loyalist) Sir Sayyid Ahmad Khan had declared Hindus and Muslims to be two separate communities and urged Muslims to work independently on their own society. For Sayyid Ahmad, the different "nationalities of India—the Muslims, the Marathas, the Brahmins, the

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"BANDE MATARAM"

The poem that became the song and slogan of the 1905 Bengal partition protests was written in 1875 by the popular Bengali novelist Bankim Chandra Chatterji (1838–94) and later incorporated into his 1882 novel *Anandamath* (Monastery of Bliss). Set at the end of the 18th century, *Anandamath* told the story of a band of patriotic armed sannyasis, devoted to the Mother Goddess (Durga Kali), who traveled the region fighting local Muslim rulers and the East India Company for the protection of Bengal's 70 million people. In Chatterji's novel, the "Mother" stood for both the goddess and the land of Bengal, a land ruled illegitimately by foreigners. Sedition laws were part of the reason Chatterji made Muslims rather than the British the villains in his novel. The novel used vivid Hindu imagery and strong anti-Muslim rhetoric. Modern 20th-century enthusiasts have often wished Chatterji's novel had a more "national" focus. At least one recent translation has accomplished this by removing the original novel's regional and anti-Muslim references, turning Chatterji's Bengal motherland into "Mother India" and morphing his long-bearded Muslim kings into the British (Chatterji 1992).

"Bande Mataram" (Bow to the Mother)
Bow to the Mother!
Watered by swiftly flowing rivers,
Rich with abundant fruits
Cooled by lovely southern breezes
Dark with harvest crops, the Mother
When 70 million voices roar out your call,
And twice 70 million hands hold sharp unwavering swords,
Why, Mother, do they call you weak!

. . . In every temple it is your image enshrined.
For as Durga, with ten weapons in ten hands,
As Lakshmi, dallying in the lotuses,
As Saraswati, the giver of wisdom,
I bow to you . . .
Bow to the Mother,
Dark-hued guileless smiling bejeweled and adorned,
The earth that supports us, the succor of us all, the Mother
(Chatterji 1989)

Sources: Chatterji, Bankim Chandra. *Anandamath* (New Delhi: Orient Paperbacks, 1992), pp. 38–4. ———. *Bankim Racanabali* (Collected works of Bankim), 13th ed. (Calcutta: Sahitya Sangsad, 1989), p. 674.

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